A Painted Solstice

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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by Eviebebeevie

Summary

Adora is going to do whatever she has to do to get Catra the perfect gift this Solstice from both her and Finn. Hand painted pottery is the way she is going to do it. Full of dinosaurs and Solstice spirit, Adora reflects on the life she and Catra have built.

Notes

I had a lot of fun writing this for the lovely Avatarbea!

This is truly just the fluffiest kid fic you'll ever read!

Adora tightens her grip on Finn's hand as they start bouncing on their toes, wide eyes taking in the inside of the pottery painting studio. The purple walls are lined with shelves of pottery in every shape imaginable: animals, princesses, mugs, you name it. The tables, carefully covered with brown paper, are each a different color and artfully painted pottery is scattered throughout the space. It was Bow's idea to take Finn to paint pottery for Catra's solstice present. Finn, like any four-year-old, loves to paint and Adora can paint something for Catra herself.

Finn's gaze stops at the wall of pottery and their tail waves in excitement as they tug on Adora's hand. "Mommy, look! A dinosaur!"

"Finn, remember this is a present for Mama," she reminds gently as she lets Finn pull her towards the pottery.

"Mama likes dinosaurs," they say resolutely as they start to reach for a t-rex shaped statue. Adora chuckles. Mama does not like dinosaurs; Finn does. They are Finn's current obsession. Dinosaur bedtime stories, dinosaur plushies, and dinosaur pajamas have been Catra and Adora's lives for the past four weeks. During the first week of this phase Finn would only speak in dinosaur noises. Their love for dinosaurs is endearing, but not exactly something Catra would choose for herself.

"Why don't we look at all the options, bud?" Adora suggests as she catches Finn's wrist before they can grab the t-rex. Finn looks up at her, their small ears pinning backwards and their lip trembling. Their eyes become glassy, as if they're about to burst

into tears at any moment. They inhale deeply, preparing to let out an ear-piercing wail.

"Okay!" Adora says quickly, moving her hands to rest on Finn's shoulders. "Okay, you can get Mama the dinosaur."

Finn's ears immediately perk up and the glassiness disappears. "Okay!" they say cheerfully, picking up the t-rex and pulling it to their chest. Adora sighs, biting back a smile— Finn is very smart and knows exactly how to get what they want. They remind Adora of Catra when they were kids. She and Catra would steal snacks from the gas station when Weaver didn't have enough food in the house; every time they got caught Catra would talk them out of trouble. She'd give them big watery eyes and a sob story that could move any convenience worker to tears. Thankfully, Finn will never have to experience that type of instability; will always be loved, wanted, and cared for. They can use their big ears and puppy-dog eyes for their wants, not their needs.

"Can we paint now?" Finn asks as they start to bounce on their toes again, eyeing the shelf of glazes.

"Mommy still needs to choose what she's going to paint for Mama," Adora says. Finn pouts. "It'll only take a second, I promise." Finn nods solemnly. Adora pauses when she realizes what exactly she said. "Promise" meant something different to Catra from Adora than to Finn. It was whispered in the dead of night, a promise that they would live until the next day. "Promise" for Finn is something simple. Easy. Finn will have everything that Catra and Adora always wanted, needed. That's why Adora is here, with Finn, creating memories her childhood self could never hope to have.

Adora takes a deep breath and starts scanning the shelves. She needs to pick something before Finn's patience wears out. She eyes a large serving platter that she thinks will work for Catra's present and picks it up.

"Okay, bud, it's time to go pay." Finn skips to the counter while Adora follows behind. Adora quickly puts the serving platter on the counter so she can take the dinosaur out of Finn's hands, before they drop it trying to put it on the counter. They huff when she takes it from them. She pays for the pottery and writes her name on the bottom of each. The teenage girl behind the counter gives Adora a smock for Finn to protect their clothes. They find a table (the green one... because it's dinosaur colored) and drop their pottery off so they can pick out the glazes.

Finn's pupils go wide as they look at all the colors they could choose. Before they start grabbing anything, Adora puts a hand on their shoulder.

"Let's pick out what colors you want your dinosaur to be. Red is Mommy's favorite color, so maybe you could do-"

"Purple!" Finn interrupts her, pointing at a speckled purple glaze.

"Are you sure? I really think Mama would like red," Adora goads, trying to get some part of Catra's present to be *for Catra.* She knows Catra will love it either way because Finn made it for her, but it would be nice for it to be something Catra likes. Finn shakes

their head, their ears hitting the sides of their head with the gesture. Adora's heart brims with adoration; she never thought she could have this life. Sometimes it still doesn't feel real that she is married to the love of her life with a family of their own.

Adora sighs and gives a bottle of the glaze to Finn. "Make sure not to drop it. Mommy's going to pick out her glaze and then we can start," Adora says as she picks out her base colors and several fine tip bottles for detail work. She then ushers Finn back to their table, setting them up with paint and a palette. She turns to her serving dish.

As she listens to Finn spout dinosaur facts, she paints a base layer of off-white and adds a couple layers of navy blue to the edge of the dish. As she waits for it to dry, she watches Finn paint their piece— it's messy, to say the least. The glaze is focused on one side of the t-rex, several layers thick in some spots and only a thin layer in others. She turns the t-rex slightly so Finn can get another angle, despite their protests.

Once the glaze on the platter is dry, she takes a pencil and carefully etches out her drawing, her tongue sticking out in concentration. She's only drawing stick figures, but she wants them to look good. Catra is the artistic one out of the two of them, always painting and sketching on their screened-in front porch. She painted a family portrait of the three of them when Finn turned two; it was the most breath-taking thing Adora had ever seen. Adora may not be artistically inclined, but she wants to try for Catra. Adora turns Finn's t-rex again and then starts on her lines. She fills in the clothing first: blue for Adora, red for Catra, and green for Finn. Then she draws their bodies with a fine black line.

By the time she finishes up with the stick figures Finn has run out of dinosaur facts and is begging to go to the park, despite yawning while asking. They definitely need a nap. She has Finn help clean up the table and they take the pottery up to the counter. The teenage girl says that they will be ready in a week, just in time for Solstice.

*

Adora can wrap presents. Well, she thought she could. She didn't need a bag, she thought; how hard could wrapping a dinosaur be? Surprisingly hard, she finding out as she's staring at the present; each end of the paper she'd wrapped around the dinosaur wrinkled to hell and ripped in some spots. Every time she tries to close the ends its curved tail or stupid tiny arms would rip right through the paper. She has already resorted to *Wikihow,* which did not help, only showing her things like balls. She huffs and stretches the leg that fell asleep out of her cross-legged position on the floor. She doesn't know how Catra does this, expertly wrapping all of Finn's presents with ease.

They never learned to wrap presents as kids— the only presents they were able to give were taped up in plastic grocery bags. As foster kids they never had money to buy presents, much less wrapping paper. When they moved into their own apartment at eighteen, they both latched onto different traditions they'd wanted but never had. For solstice, Adora loves decorating the house, always buying too many ugly decorations from the thrift stores around them. Every year she goads Catra into redecorating the entire house in greens, oranges, and yellows. They hang up dried orange slices and cover the house with cheap plastic fir tree

branches. Adora almost falls off the roof at least once a year hanging up the icicle lights they splurged on the first year they had their house.

Catra focused on gift giving. She has a locked list on her notes app of gift ideas for everyone in their life. Oftentimes Adora will receive something she mentioned liking in passing six months before solstice, or a beautiful hand-made piece of art like the family portrait from two years ago. She set her mind to being able to wrap beautiful presents; she used to dig through the dollar store wrapping paper, but now she buys the fancy thick kind. She always decorates them with bows and ribbons.

It's adorable, but hard to live up to, Adora thinks as she tries to wrap this dinosaur. Its arms keep ripping the paper, leading Adora to be circled by balls of discarded wrapping paper. She only has half an hour left before Catra comes home from work with Finn in tow; she needs to get this done *now*. She wracks her brain trying to figure out who to call to help her with this: Bow is in class with his students so he can't answer, Glimmer isn't any better at wrapping presents than her, and anything that is told to Perfuma and Scorpia will find its way directly back to Catra.

Adora scrolls through her contacts and lands on one she never calls, but she knows will be able to help. She clicks on the name and listens to the phone ring.

"*Hello?"* Angella answers, obviously confused by the random phone call.

“Hi, I am so so sorry to bother you. It's just that I am trying to wrap Catra’s presents before she gets home and Finn picked out this t-rex to paint, and I can’t figure out how to wrap it. The paper keeps ripping and I’m running out of time and I-”

“*Adora,*” Angella stops her. “*Take a breath.*” Adora inhales deeply and blows the air out in a steady stream, her heart rate slowing.

“*Good. Now, you just need to put it in a box and then wrap it.*”

“Oh.” Now that Adora thinks about it, she’d seen Catra do that countless times with things that are oddly shaped. There’s a reason Catra hordes boxes starting in November. She feels a little like an idiot for not thinking of it herself, but she can wrap a box before Catra gets home. That’s easy.

She thanks Angella and hangs up the call before rummaging through the corner of their garage where Catra keeps the extra boxes. She finds one that is the right size and heads back to the living room. She hums to the solstice music that has been in her head since Finn has started requesting it be played during every car ride. She smiles to herself as she wraps the gift; Catra is going to love it.

*

Catra wakes up Solstice morning to Finn jumping on her stomach, all the air exiting her lungs with a groan. She opens her eyes to

see Finn sitting on her in their solstice pajamas, blonde hair wild and sticking up in every direction. Adora is standing next to the bed holding two presents. She mouths *I'm sorry* as Finn bounces up and down. She glances at the clock on the nightstand to see it's six in the morning— far earlier than she ever wants to be awake during the holidays, but Finn's grin makes it worth it.

"Mama, it's Solstice!"

"I can see that, Finnie. Are you excited?" Catra asks, ruffling their hair. They nod eagerly, their blue eyes shining. They're so cute that Catra can almost forgive them for how little she can breathe with them sitting on her stomach like this.

"So excited that they woke Mommy up at four in the morning," Adora informs her as she comes closer with the gifts. Catra's eyes widen as she sees the deep circles under Adora's own. She makes a mental note to thank Adora later for letting her sleep in, even if it was just two more hours. "They wanted to give you your presents."

"My presents?" Catra questions, surprised. She was expecting that Finn would want to open their presents, not have Catra open hers.

Adora shrugs, a soft smile on her face. She puts the presents on the bedside table and coaxes Finn off Catra so she can sit up against the headboard. Finn grabs the smaller gift and shoves it into Catra's hands. They watch with excitement as Catra carefully unwraps the gift; it's small and rectangular. Adora obviously tried hard to wrap it, it's done exactly how Catra taught her. She opens

the cardboard box to find a ceramic t-rex. Its purple paint is uneven and messy, some parts left completely blank. Catra smiles widely as she turns it in her hands. It is so Finn. Her chest brims with emotion. She looks up at Finn's smiling face. Their ears twitch and tail waves in excitement.

"Finn, I love it! You did such a good job, baby. I'm going to put it on the mantle where everyone can see," she praises as she puts the piece down and scoops Finn into a big hug, peppering their face with kisses as they giggle.

Adora inches forwards and holds out a round flat gift wrapped in the same cat-themed wrapping paper as Finn's. "This one is from me."

Catra nudges Finn out of her lap and takes the gift. She unwraps the gift to see a serving platter. Tears spring up as she takes it in; It is off-white with a navy-blue strip around the edge. In the middle are three stick figures holding hands with their names written above them in Adora's round handwriting, the 'i's dotted with circles. The first is obviously Adora, complete with an exaggerated hair poof. The second one is Finn, with tiny cat ears and spikey hair, and the last is her, her cat ears poking out of a mass of hair and three freckles on each cheek. All three stick figures are smiling.

Catra holds back a sob. This is everything she has ever wanted—to have a life, a family, with Adora. Every day she feels like she is waking up in a dream. There was a time when she didn't even think she would make it to eighteen, and now she has a house and a kid and Adora as her wife. She puts down the serving

platter next to the t-rex on the side table and pulls Adora down into her arms, burying her face into her shoulder. “I love you.”

“I love you too, Cat,” Adora promises as she presses a kiss to Catra’s ear.

Finn decides that they don’t have enough attention and decides to shove themself in between Adora and Catra, forcing them to readjust to accommodate Finn in between them. Catra gives a wet chuckle and places a kiss between their ears. This is the only place Catra wants to be, here with Finn and Adora in the life they have created together.

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